we know a lot about Mackenzie, and it is impossible not to warm to him. He had the luck to meet at the start of his surveying an eighteen-year-old named Kavali Venkata Boriah who came from a remarkable family of Telugu Niyogi Brahmin brothers and was fluent in Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Sanskrit. Boriah became Mackenzie's main translator and information-gatherer, and came to be regarded by him more as a son than an employee. 'The connection then formed with one person,' Mackenzie later wrote in a letter to a friend, 'then almost a youth of the quickest genius and disposition, possessing that conciliatory turn of mind that soon reconciled all sects and all tribes … was the first step of my introduction into the portal of Indian knowledge. Devoid of any knowledge of the languages myself, I owe to the happy genius of this individual the encouragement and the means of obtaining what I had so long sought … A new avenue to Hindoo knowledge was opened.'[2]

This was written after Boriah's sudden death in 1803, which hit Mackenzie hard. However, by then no fewer than four of Boriah's brothers had joined Mackenzie's team, one of whom, Kavali Venkata Laksmiah, stepped into Boriah's shoes. When Mackenzie himself died in 1821 it was Laksmiah who worked with the appointed executor to compile an inventory of Mackenzie's vast collection. Laksmiah was the first Indian to be accepted as a member of the Madras Literary Society and the first to be made an honorary member of the Royal Asiatic Society in Britain.

This closeness to his Brahmin assistants may explain why it took Mackenzie so long to realise that Jainism was a separate religion from Hinduism. His first recorded encounter with the Jain religion came on 24 February 1797 while he was engaged in surveying what the British knew then as Canara country, south of Hyderabad. He had camped at a hamlet called Ibrahimpatnam – now an ugly industrial town – and was working his way along the north